

# Guest-Speaker Engagement — Template and Rubric

**Questions in advance + one-page summary report (3 speakers × 5% = 15% of the grade)**

Applied Data Science and AI in Pharma Commercial · Columbia University · Fall 2026

**Speaker 1: Nov 16 — Agentic AI use cases in pharma commercial · Speaker 2: Nov 30 — The journey of marketing mix in pharma: from regression to agents · Speaker 3: Dec 14 — industry panel**

**Questions due: the Friday before each session, 5:00 PM ET · Summary due: one week after the session, 11:59 PM ET · Late submissions not accepted**

---

## Why this counts for 15%

The syllabus's second deliberate goal is direct, sustained exposure to industry experts. Practitioners judge students less by what they know than by the quality of the questions they ask. This component rewards preparation (questions that show you have read about the speaker's domain) and synthesis (a summary a manager would find useful).

## Part 1 — Questions in advance (2 points)

Submit three questions on the course site by the Friday deadline. The instructor forwards a curated set to the speaker; the best questions are asked live and credited by name.

| Criterion               | Full credit                                                                               | Partial                | No credit                |
|-------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------|--------------------------|
| <b>Specificity</b>      | References the speaker's actual role, company or a published piece of their work          | Generic to the topic   | Could be asked of anyone |
| <b>Analytical depth</b> | Asks about a trade-off, a failure, a measurement problem or a decision                    | Asks for a description | Yes/no or factual lookup |
| <b>Course linkage</b>   | Connects to a week's method (MMM, NBA, forecasting, NLP, agents) or a stakeholder tension | Loosely related        | Unrelated                |

### Examples of strong questions

“Your team moved from a regression MMM to a Bayesian one — what decision changed as a result, and did the CFO trust the wider intervals?”

“When an agent drafts the weekly brand briefing, who is accountable for a wrong number, and how did you design the review step?”

“Which stakeholder's behavior was hardest to get data on — payer, HCP or patient — and what proxy did you end up using?”

## Part 2 — One-page summary report (3 points)

One page (≈450–600 words), PDF, submitted within a week of the session. Write it as a memo to a manager who could not attend. Use the headings below.

| Heading                                      | Content                                                                                              | Points |
|----------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------|
| The problem the speaker solves               | Two or three sentences: which stakeholder, which decision, which data                                | 0.5    |
| Three takeaways                              | Concrete and specific: numbers, examples, named trade-offs — not “AI is important”                   | 1.0    |
| What surprised you or what you disagree with | One paragraph with a reason; disagreement is welcome if argued                                       | 0.5    |
| Connection to the course                     | Which week’s method this relates to and how the speaker’s practice differs from the textbook version | 0.5    |
| One question you would ask next              | A follow-up that builds on the talk                                                                  | 0.5    |

*Formatting: your name, the speaker and the date at the top; one page; no bullet-only reports. AI use must be disclosed per the syllabus policy; the summary must be your own writing.*

## Question submission form

| Field                        | Your entry |
|------------------------------|------------|
| Your name                    |            |
| Speaker / session            |            |
| Question 1                   |            |
| Why you're asking (one line) |            |
| Question 2                   |            |
| Why you're asking (one line) |            |
| Question 3                   |            |
| Why you're asking (one line) |            |